

The Last WALTZ

Long has Soren played a double game with the BJP and Congress. This time he may have overreached himself.

By Amitabh Srivastava

From agonising the BJP to appeasing it with apologies, from checkmating the Congress to cheering it with capitulations, the notoriously narcissistic Shibu Soren did everything possible to cling on to what he cherishes most. With the Jharkhand chief minister's chair the solitary driver, 66-year-old Soren and his son Hemant made promises to the BJP while sending feelers to the Congress. The Sorens wanted the son to succeed the father as Jharkhand's chief minister. To achieve this, the father-son duo was seen hunting with the hounds and running with the rabbits.

The trouble was that they were doing everything concurrently. The elasticity of their appeals did not help when the BJP called the Sorens' bluff and pulled the support rug from under their feet on May 24. The father-son duo fell flat on their faces. The Congress had already started salivating at the possibility of back-seat driving during President's rule in the state. So, the grand old party continued its hands-off policy to avoid sewing a deleterious deal with someone as power-hungry as Soren Senior.

As it turned out on the sultry Sunday night of May 30, Soren realised he had run out of options just a day before he was to face a trial of strength in the Assembly. His last hope—that of BJP MLAs rescuing his government or the Congress breaking its alliance with Babulal Marandi's

Jharkhand Vikas Morcha (JVM) and offering him crutches—receded when both the NDA and the UPA declared they would vote against the confidence motion. When he arrived at Raj Bhawan to put in his papers, Soren's demeanour indicated that the hopes and hype the father and son had created about saving the government had no substance.

Soren, who is an MP, was to be elected to the Assembly by June 30, failing which he would have had to resign as chief minister. But he wanted more: a place in the Union Cabinet with Hemant ruling Jharkhand. But regardless of their best laid plans, the two knocked themselves off centre-stage. Soren is the only politician in the country who had to put in six resignations in as many years—thrice as Union minister and thrice as Jharkhand chief minister. Now, with 18 MLAs in the 81-member Assembly, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) may still have a role in future government formation, but Soren is unlikely to be king. Major parties in Jharkhand view him as untrustworthy, unpredictable and worse, ungrateful.

Soren's resignation capped 33 days of uncertainty since he voted



SHIBU SOREN (LEFT) WITH SON HEMANT

against a cut motion moved by the BJP in the Lok Sabha on April 27. In the aftermath, the BJP declared withdrawal of support but did not go ahead when the Sorens offered them the top post. The BJP finally pulled out of the alliance when Soren refused to vacate the chair for them.

A day later Jharkhand Governor M.O.H. Farook recommended President's rule after three major parties—the BJP, Congress and Jharkhand Vikas Morcha-Prajantrik (JVM-P)—informed him that they did not have the numbers to form a government. On June 1, the procla-

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